

Wildcats to retain Jim Wing's coaching expertise

The best thing that's happened to the University of Arizona baseball program since the season ended early last month is what didn't happen.

Jim Wing is still with the ball club.

Wing is the top assistant to Coach Jerry Kindall, and one of the most knowledgeable baseball teachers in the country. He is a one-man think-tank, a peerless judge of talent and an energetic leader.

Wing also has been the top candidate for head coach at Texas-El Paso, a school that thinks it wants a competitive baseball program, but isn't quite sure. UTEP's summer-long dalliance in finding a successor to 73-year-old volunteer coach Andy Cohen apparently has cost the Miners the best prospect in the U.S.

Wing has signed a contract to return to UA.

Arizona lost its entire pitching rotation to graduation and the professional draft. But there are many who'd tell you losing Wing would hurt more.

His primary responsibility is handing the pitching and catching. In those departments, Wing's work has been superb. But his contributions to the baseball program have amounted to much more.

He has a special gift of observing the tiniest flaw in batting stances, grips, fielding positions, throwing, running . . . everything to do with the game.

Wing has been Kindall's assistant at UA for six seasons. He coached at Palo Verde High School here for eight years and was junior varsity coach at Tucson



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High five years. His combined high school record was 162-73.

Like Kindall, Wing was born in Minnesota. He graduated from Tucson High, where he was an outstanding catcher, in 1964. He matriculated at UA, but a shoulder injury cut his baseball career short.

"I have a feeling about the opportunity at UTEP as a 'sleeping giant,'" Wing said. "But for all intents and purposes, I'll be a member of the 1979 staff at UA, and I'm very excited about it. I'm glad to be a part of the UA program. I think we're going to have a very interesting year."

"I wish the season started next week. I can't wait to get our guys on campus and get started."

"I look at other colleges around the country and compare what they have to our facilities. Heck, there just isn't any comparison."

Pitching, of course, will be the big question mark next season for the Wildcats of Kindall and Wing. UA lost its top four hurlers, Dave Crutcher, Craig Chamberlain, Ray Munillo and Bob Chaulk — the first two to the pro draft and the others to graduation.

"We have some quality players coming in, though, and I think we'll have a very good team," Wing said. "I'd be kidding you if I said pitching is where we'd like it to be. But in college ball, you get used to starting all over. And we'll have some good people to rebuild with."

One area where the Wildcats should be exceptionally strong is the outfield. The Cats return Scott Stanley, Randy Roeder and Terry Francona, each a proven fly-catcher and solid hitter. John Moses, a

prize recruit from Golden West Community College in California, probably will battle Roeder for the starting center field spot. Moses is a speed demon (38 stolen bases last season) and a switch-hitter of remarkable skill.

The Cats return Brad Mills at third base, a .437 currently laying with Kenai Peninsula in Alaska. Francona is with the Fairbanks Goldpanners.

Catching should also be a strong point, with all three backstoppers returning. David Fortman, Scott Overlund and Ron Kirby all will be back.

The only weakness, on paper, is in pitching. But with Kindall's proven recruiting talent and Wing's ability to refine the product, UA should be a contender in the Pacific-10 Conference.